

MICHAEL'S LIBRARY

Holy Fire

by R.T. Kendall

2014

CHAPTER 1

The Need for Holy Fire

DISCERNING THE TIMES The Spirit clearly says that in later times some will abandon the faith and follow deceiving spirits and things taught by demons. . . . For the time will come when men will not put up with sound doctrine. Instead, to suit their own desires, they will gather around them a great number of teachers to say what their itching ears want to hear. They will turn their ears away from the truth and turn aside to myths.

But you, keep your head in all situations. —1 TIMOTHY 4:1; 2 TIMOTHY 4:3–5, NIV The worst thing that can happen to a man is to succeed before he is ready. —D. MARTYN LLOYD-JONES I WRITE THIS BOOK FOR THE YOUNG CHRISTIAN, THE NEW CHRISTIAN, the theological student, the new pastor, but also the seasoned layman or minister who aspires more than ever to be jealous for the honor and glory of God.

I write also for the fence straddler out there who is sincerely baffled and unsure of what to believe about the Holy Spirit. Jonathan Edwards said that the one thing Satan cannot produce in us is a love for the glory of God. So if the reading of this book results in a greater love for the honor of God and deeper reverence for the Holy Spirit, you may be sure that the devil did not put that desire and respect there.

This is also why Edwards stated that when the church is revived, so is the devil! So you may count on the devil putting every obstacle in your way to rob you of the joy that comes from intimacy with the Holy Spirit. Indeed, Satan will do everything he possibly can to lure you away from tasting the genuine power of the living God. I want to anticipate certain cautions you may face down the road.

Whether your background is conservative evangelical, Reformed, charismatic, or Pentecostal, there are certain pitfalls you need to be aware of. In each of these streams you need to be armed to withstand the pressures that come from a revengeful Satan who does not want you to grow in grace and knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ. “My people are destroyed from lack of knowledge” (Hos. 4:6). In this connection I would mention (1) lack of knowledge of God’s Word and (2) lack of knowledge of God’s ways.

The first thing is the reading of the Bible. The devil does not want you to read your Bible, much less spend a lot of time reading the Bible. How well do you know your Bible? To understand the Bible you must be on good terms with the Holy Spirit. He wrote the Bible (2 Tim. 3:15; 2 Pet. 1:21). He alone can open your mind to understand His own Word.

When we grieve the Holy Spirit through bitterness or quench Him through fear, the inevitable result is an inability to focus on His Word. And yet to put it the other way around, to be on good terms with the Holy Spirit you need to know your Bible—and know it well. I fear there are ministers around who never seriously read the

Bible through but only consult the Bible when it comes to preparing a sermon.

You need a Bible reading plan. For years I have recommended the plan designed by Robert Murray M'Cheyne (1813–1843), which Dr. Martyn Lloyd-Jones introduced to me the first week I was the minister of Westminster Chapel in 1977.¹ It takes you through the whole Bible in a year including the New Testament twice and Psalms twice. This keeps you in God's Word. I heartily recommend it. You will never be sorry you started this and stayed with it.

Be a Christian who knows his or her Bible. This is so pleasing to God. Second, the way you know someone's ways is by spending time with them. You show your esteem of a person by how much time you give them. So I will come right to the point: How much do you pray? The devil does not want you to pray, much less spend a lot of time praying.

And Satan trembles, when he sees The weakest saint upon his knees.² —WILLIAM COWPER (1731–1800) I urge at least thirty minutes a day in your quiet time—including Bible reading and prayer. For the person in full-time Christian ministry, I suggest a minimum of an hour a day (two is better), and this should be for private devotions and quiet time without using any of this time for sermon preparation. Martin Luther spent two hours a day in prayer.

John Wesley spent two hours a day in prayer. According to a recent poll taken on both sides of the Atlantic, the average church leader (pastor, priest, evangelist, teacher) today spends four minutes

a day in prayer.³ And you wonder why the church is powerless? Where are the Luthers today? Where are the Wesleys? Who is truly turning the world upside down? As for time in prayer, if you don't know how to use up that time, get a prayer list.

Pray for people who will never know you prayed for them. Pray for your friends. Pray for your enemies. There will be no praying in heaven. I would lovingly plead with you: spend much time in prayer now. Get to know God and His ways by spending time with Him. THE GOD OF THE BIBLE VERSUS DANGEROUS TEACHINGS I cannot predict exactly what obstacles you will face, but I will mention briefly some that are at large.

For example, if you are in a charismatic or Pentecostal church, there are some strange teachings you will likely be confronted with. They come down basically to one thing: your view of God. The God of the Bible is sovereign, omnipotent, omnipresent, omniscient, and holy. In my books *The God of the Bible* (CrossBooks) and *Totally Forgiving God* (Charisma House) I share these attributes of God in more detail. 1.

The sovereignty of God refers to His divine right to do what He pleases. “I will have mercy on whom I will have mercy” (Exod. 33:19; Rom. 9:15). He “works out everything in conformity with the purpose of his will” (Eph. 1:11). 2. The God of the Bible is omnipotent—all powerful. There is nothing He cannot do (Luke 1:37). 3. The God of the Bible is omnipresent. He is everywhere; there is no place He is not present.

Always be looking for His manifest presence. Peter called this, “times of refreshing” (Acts 3:19). 4. He is omniscient—He knows everything, past, present and future. Yes, He knows the future as perfectly as He knows the past, declaring the end from the beginning (Isa. 46:10). 5. The God of the Bible is a holy God. He demands holiness of us in our personal and private lives (1 Pet. 1:16). Never forget that you and I will stand before the judgment seat of Christ one day to receive what is “due” us for the things done “while in the body, whether good or bad” (2 Cor.

5:10). A defective view of the God of the Bible has resulted in dangerous teachings in recent years in certain charismatic or Pentecostal circles. By Pentecostal I mainly mean a denomination—such as Assemblies of God, Pentecostal Holiness, Foursquare Gospel, Church of God, and Elim. By charismatic I refer to a movement that grew up spontaneously in the 1960s, stressing the gifts of the Holy Spirit (especially speaking in tongues) and crossed denominational lines—for example, Episcopal, Reformed, Baptist, Lutheran, and Presbyterian.

I’m afraid there are a lot of strange teachings out there that have crept into these churches or movements. One is called hyper-grace teaching. I will mention this heresy yet again in chapter 5—“Strange Fire.” The view comes to this: since Jesus dealt with all our sin on the cross, there is no need to confess sin—it has already been dealt with. No need for repentance in the Christian life, say these people.

This is tantamount to antinomianism (anti-law) and can so easily lead to ungodly living. The people who uphold this kind of thinking have actually had to eliminate certain books of the Bible, for example, Hebrews and 1 John. Imagine that! To uphold a teaching they have to cut out part of the canon of Holy Scripture! I warn you, this teaching grieves the Holy Spirit. It is a fad. It will not last.

But it can do incalculable damage in the meantime. The second teaching I mention here and again in chapter 5 is called open theism. This view of God brings Him down to the level of man so that such a God does not know His own mind without our input. The idea is that we actually help God know what to do next; without us He cannot move forward. This is sub-Christian teaching.

It has astonishingly crept into certain charismatic circles. When one leader of this teaching was asked publicly in London, “With this view of God, is it not possible that God could lose out in the end?” The reply was: Yes. Imagine a God like that. The God of the Bible wins! Such a weak view of God is the ultimate consequence of denying His eternal sovereignty. On the heels of open theism is the notion that we can virtually make God do anything.

We can decree something, and it will come to pass. This makes man sovereign. It is sometimes a part of the health and wealth and prosperity teachings. While it is absolutely true that God promises to bless the tither (Mal. 3:10)—for we cannot outgive the Lord (2 Cor. 9:8), beware of those who pitch this point of view mainly to advance their personal ministries. Some leaders go so far as to claim that their

words of knowledge are superior to Holy Scripture.

Some deny the Bible as being the complete and final revelation of eternal truth. One leader said, “If the apostle Paul had my faith, he would not have had a thorn in the flesh.” I’m sorry, but this kind of doctrine has emerged in charismatic and Pentecostal settings. Be wise to teaching that exalts any man or woman and even appeals to a person’s greed. They emerge from strange fire, teachings that are alien to Holy Scripture.

However, do not let your view of the infallibility of Holy Scripture keep you from believing that God speaks to us directly today. He does. Do not believe for one moment that the God of the Bible does not perform miracles today. He does. And don’t abandon your view that the Bible is God’s final and complete revelation of eternal truth. It is. My prayer is that you will uphold Holy Scripture as God’s infallible Word while simultaneously believing that God is unchanging in His willingness to manifest His power (Mal.

3:6; Heb. 13:8). It would therefore be a great pity—and a victory for Satan—if you let strange teachings disillusion you. I write this book to encourage you to wait for and expect the conscious and manifest presence of the third person of the Godhead—the Holy Spirit. T W HEOLOGY AND ORSHIP Having had one foot in the Reformed camp and the other in the charismaticPentecostal camp, I have been increasingly alarmed at the trend in some of the worship among the latter camp.

The early Methodists got their theology mostly from their hymns. This made them theologically minded—a trait you and I must never lose. Whose hymns did the early Methodists sing? They sang those written by such people as Isaac Watts (1674–1748), Charles Wesley (1707–1788), William Cowper, and John Newton (1725– 1807). Read them. Sing them. Have you had a look lately at the words of hymns such as, “And can it be that I should gain an int’rest in my Savior’s blood?,”⁴ “When I survey the wondrous cross on which the Prince of glory died,”⁵ “God moves in a mysterious way His wonders to perform,”⁶ “How sweet the name of Jesus sounds,”⁷ or “O for a heart to praise my God, a heart from sin set free”⁸?

I would plead for the present generation of all Christians to sing the new as well as the old. Jesus spoke a parable about “the owner of a house who brings out of his storeroom new treasures as well as old” (Matt. 13:52), a truth that could readily apply to new and old hymns. What worries me most about some contemporary worship is its lack of good theology. Some seem to have almost no theology at all!

This is not good. I fear that we are producing a generation of people who are vulnerable to heretical movements partly because of a lack of good grounding in the truth. That said, I thank God for hymns such as Chris Bowater’s “Jesus Shall Take the Highest Honour”; Graham Kendrick’s “Restore, O Lord,” “Knowing You, Jesus,” and “Such Love”; Stuart Townend’s “How Deep the Father’s Love For Us” and “In Christ Alone”; Matt Redman’s “Blessed Be Your Name” and “10,000 Reasons”; Stephen Fry’s “Oh the Glory of

His Presence”; Darlene Zschech’s “Shout to the Lord”; and others.

But there are pitfalls in conservative Evangelicalism too. One teaching that is common in Reformed theology is called cessationism. The idea is that the miraculous ceased sometime after the last apostle died or when the canon of Scripture was complete. This concept is so important I will devote both chapters 8 and 9 to it. Cessationism is not a fad. It has been around for a long time. Those who uphold this are not heretics.

They are good people. But cessationism quenches the Holy Spirit as much as the previously mentioned teachings that displease Him. You will not likely convince a cessationist to believe that the living God heals supernaturally today. A man convinced against his will is of the same opinion still! I just don’t want some of these people to convince you! So do not let those who hold to their views that God will not manifest His power today deter you from seeing the God of glory show Himself in our generation.

That is why I write this book. As I said, my own theological stable is Reformed. But I came into it not by reading Reformed theology. My purpose in writing this book, however, is not to change your theology but to make you hungry for the Holy Spirit. If you walk in the Spirit, know your Bible, and spend sufficient time alone with God, your theology will take care of itself.

My greatest mentor was Dr. Martyn Lloyd-Jones. Through this book I want to make him better known and a blessing to you as much as he was to me. The greatest thing he ever said to me was

this: “The worst thing that can happen to a man is to succeed before he is ready.” This statement is what helped me keep my head when God did not manifest His power in my own ministry as quickly as I hoped.

But I never gave up. I don’t want you to give up! Chapter Two WHAT EVERY CHRISTIAN SHOULD KNOW ABOUT THE HOLY SPIRIT I will ask the Father, and he will give you another Helper, to be with you forever, even the Spirit of truth . . . he dwells with you and will be in you. —JOHN 14:16–17, ESV If the Holy Spirit was withdrawn from the church today, 95 percent of what we do would go on and no one would know the difference.

—A. W. TOZER (1897–1963) THE DISCIPLES OF JESUS DID NOT ENJOY HEARING ABOUT THE Holy Spirit. It made them uneasy, as we will see below. Today some Christians feel much the same way. The mention of Him makes them uneasy. There can be many reasons for this. In the case of conservative evangelicals, they sometimes think that charismatics talk more about the Holy Spirit than they do about Jesus or the gospel.

In my own experience I have often observed that there